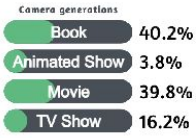
Middle Earth

Identifying Middle Earth



Most of Middle Earth has a **rugged, natural landscape**. Vegetation ranges from dense forests to wide open plains. In many regions, mountains are common.

Middle Earth is populated by a wide range of **fantastical creatures**.

NOTE: While much of Middle Earth shares a striking resemblance to New Zealand, the two can often be differentiated by the fact that New Zealand does not have any living elves, dragons, orcs, or other magical creatures.

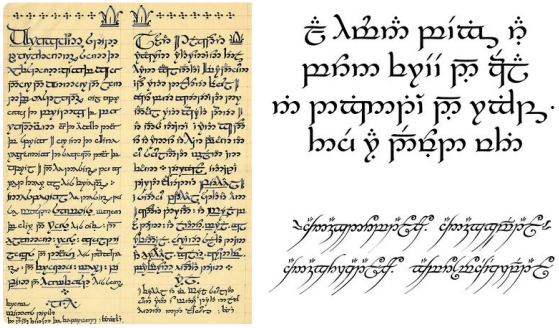
The architecture of Middle earth has a distinct **medieval look** to it.

NOTE: Buildings in New Zealand are much more modern.

As there are no cars in Middle Earth, most of the imagery was captured using cameras mounted to **horses**. This is not found anywhere else.

Middle Earth mostly drives on the **left**. However, this is not standardised by local governments, so there can be exceptions.

You will never find asphalt roads in Middle Earth. All roads are either unpaved or have a cobblestone surface.



A variety of different scripts are used in Middle Earth. The most common one is **Tengwar**, which can be recognized by its curvy look, with lots of flourishes and accents. Uniquely, it features triple dots.

Middle Earth's **town entrance signs** look like this.

This "You Shall Not Pass" road sign is unique to Middle Earth.

NOTE: It is most common in the Mines of Moria.

Regional clues

Most of the Shire is situated on green, agricultural rolling hills, with a particular type of small houses built **into the ground**, commonly having very distinct **round doors**.

Mordor has a volcanic landscape, with distinct **black soil**.

While **horses and horse-riding** are the main form of transportation in most of Middle Earth, it is especially common in Rohan. This is also reflected in its flag, which prominently depicts a stylized horse.

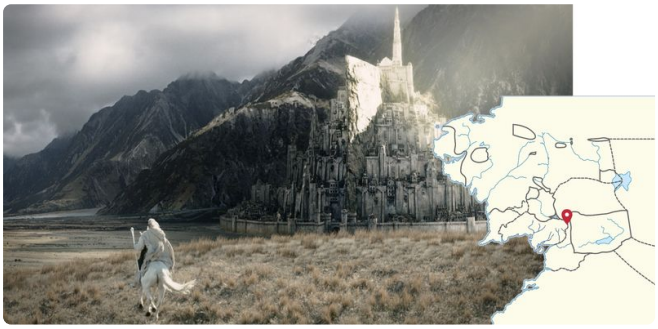
Buildings in Rohan are almost always made of wood and often have thatched roofs. Uniquely, a lot of buildings have roofs with cross beams that are **shaped like horses**, reflecting the equestrian culture.

Fangorn forest can often be recognized by its old-looking **walking trees**.

The Northern Waste region has a unique **cold** and **mountainous** landscape, which makes it very recognisable.

The Dead Marshes can be recognised from the **wet landscape**, filled with **dead bushes**, and little greenery.

Spotlight



The **white city** of Minas Tirith, in the eastern parts of Gondor, can be seen from afar and is easily recognizable due to its distinct shape and colour.

Minas Morgul is a large fortress, situated in a dark valley near the border between Gondor and Mordor, which is typically illuminated with **green light**.

The elven castle of Rivendell is located in a slim valley, surrounded by **extremely tall cliff sides** and a multitude of small waterfalls.

Mount Doom and the tower of Barad-dûr, crowned by the Eye of Sauron, can both be found in the **northwestern** part of Mordor and can often be seen from very far away.

The tower of Isengard can be seen from afar and somewhat resembles Barad-dûr in Mordor. It can however easily be differentiated by the fact that there is **no large burning eye** at the top.

Erebor is a tall, sharp and recognizable **lonely mountain** in northern Rhovanion.

The former stronghold of the Dark Lord, Dol Guldur, is an **ancient ruin** situated northeast of Rohan. It typically has a somewhat creepy feel to it.

The deep, **fortified gorge** of Helm's Deep, in western Rohan is surrounded by tall mountains, and has a small, flat wetland in front of it.

Lake-town is a town **built on water** in the northwestern part of the Long Lake in Rhovanion.

The mines of Moria can be recognized by its **darkness** combined with the dwarven architecture.

The forest of Lothlórien can be recognized by the **sharp blue tint** to the coverage, combined with the extravagant elven architecture.